WASEL — RIDER DEMAND PLAYBOOK

Behavioral Economics × Growth Strategy | March 2026

> *“"Build habit before you build brand. Build trust before you build scale.""*

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The driver side of Wasel is solved. The platform earns when drivers subscribe. But driver subscriptions are only valuable if riders generate trips. This playbook provides a research-backed, behaviorally grounded, market-specific system to unlock rider demand, frequency, and retention.

Every idea in this playbook meets three criteria:

1. **Implementable:** Technically and operationally realistic in Jordan, Iraq, and comparable markets
2. **Economically sound:** No negative unit economics — no subsidized rides, no unsustainable discounts
3. **Behaviorally grounded:** Every lever is supported by academic research or proven case studies

SECTION 1: RIDER PSYCHOLOGY BREAKDOWN

Six Psychological Levers That Drive or Kill Rider Behavior

1. Price Sensitivity (The Dominant Force)

Sourced Fact: Price is the #1 decision factor for approximately 69% of ride-hailing users globally, with the proportion rising significantly in developing markets. In LATAM, 45.5% cite competitive pricing as the biggest factor. [TGM Research, 2024]

Sourced Fact: Riders with high price sensitivity and low frequency are driven by necessity and motivated primarily by affordability and value for money. They compare prices across platforms and use ride-hailing only during promotions. [ScienceDirect, Pricing & Efficiency study]

Behavioral mechanism: Price sensitivity in developing markets is not just rational comparison — it is emotionally amplified. In Jordan, where average monthly salary is JD 500–600, a JD 2.37 fare represents ~0.4% of monthly income. At scale, this triggers loss aversion — the fear of paying "too much" is disproportionately powerful relative to the actual sum.

Implication for Wasel: The platform already has a structural 5% fare advantage over incumbents. This must be communicated explicitly, not left implicit. A rider who does not know they are paying less will not change their behavior.

2. Convenience and Time Sensitivity (The Segment Divider)

Sourced Fact: Research using detailed auction data from a large ride-hailing platform found that the top quartile of riders by value of time have VOT measures approximately 3.5× higher than the bottom quartile. [Buchholz et al., Econometrica, 2025]

Sourced Fact: Spatial variation in value of time is significant — riders in city centres have higher VOT than those in periphery areas. [Buchholz et al., Econometrica, 2025]

Behavioral mechanism: The urban Jordanian rider travelling in Abdali or Shmeisani is not the same psychology as the rider in Tabarbour or Zarqa. The first is time-maximizing; the second is cost-minimizing. Wasel must segment messaging accordingly.

Implication for Wasel: Two distinct rider acquisition tracks are needed: (1) Speed-promise messaging for central business district riders (professionals, corporates), and (2) Fair-price / savings messaging for residential and peripheral riders (families, students, workers).

3. Trust and Safety (The Gating Factor)

Sourced Fact: Trust has been found to fully mediate the relationship between perceived booking app-related risks, satisfaction, and loyalty. [PMC / Frontiers in Public Health, 2022]

Sourced Fact: Privacy concerns reduce pooled rideshare adoption by 77%. [MDPI, 2024]

Sourced Fact: Women are more likely to value driver information visibility and the presence of a panic button, and these features directly influence their intention to continue using the service. [World Bank, Driving Toward Equality; Nature Communications, 2024]

Behavioral mechanism: Trust is not a soft metric — it is the gating variable. A rider who does not trust the platform will not convert even if fares are superior. For female riders in Jordan (who are 28.51% more likely to use ride-hailing than male riders), trust signals are the single biggest lever for frequency increase. [PMC study on demographic factors]

Implication for Wasel: Safety and trust features are not "nice to have" — they are direct demand drivers. Every additional trust signal increases conversion and retention, particularly among female riders who represent disproportionate upside.

4. Habit Formation (The Frequency Engine)

Sourced Fact: Economic incentives significantly increased ride-hailing uptake, and the effect persisted for months after removing the incentive, driven mainly by initial low users — providing direct evidence for habit formation. [ResearchGate, 14,000-person natural experiment]

Sourced Fact: Hedonic value (emotional satisfaction) and utilitarian value (practical benefit) jointly mediate continuance intention in ride-hailing apps. Neither alone is sufficient. [ScienceDirect, Post-adoption behavior study, Egypt]

Behavioral mechanism: The habit loop in ride-hailing follows a clear structure: Cue (need to travel) → Routine (open Wasel) → Reward (arrive safely, save money). Once the routine is established — typically requiring 3–5 consistent repetitions — switching cost increases dramatically, even in the absence of monetary lock-in.

Implication for Wasel: The first three rides are critical. A rider who completes three trips within their first two weeks is significantly more likely to form a durable habit than one who takes one ride and waits a week. Interventions that accelerate this initial cluster of rides have outsized long-term value.

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5. Status and Social Perception (The Amplifier)

Sourced Fact: Social influence is a significant driver of behavioral intention to use ride-hailing apps. [IEOMSOCIETY, Singapore, 2025]

Sourced Fact: Local ambassador programs and "Built in the region, for the region" branding fostered loyalty and pride for Careem in MENA. [Michigan Journal of Economics, 2025]

Behavioral mechanism: In Jordan specifically, where regional identity and community belonging are culturally salient, being seen as a "supporter of a Jordanian platform" carries social capital. The boycott of Uber/Careem has already activated this social identity dimension. Being a Wasel rider becomes an identity signal, not just a transport choice.

Implication for Wasel: Visible, shareable markers of Wasel use (branded receipts, shareable ride summaries, rider milestones) create social proof loops. The brand itself can function as a tribal signal in a politically aware market.

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6. Control and Transparency (The Anxiety Reducer)

Sourced Fact: Dynamic surge pricing creates dissatisfaction and triggers strategic gaming behavior — riders wait for prices to drop, causing demand oscillations. [ScienceDirect, Pricing fast and slow, 2025]

Sourced Fact: Price variability is an "undesirable experience that can cause reduced engagement of both riders and drivers." [Management Science, Matching and Pricing in Ride-Hailing]

Behavioral mechanism: Uncertainty causes anxiety. Anxiety reduces usage frequency. The moment a rider is unsure what their next ride will cost — due to surge pricing — they hesitate, delay, or switch. Predictability is not just a preference; it is a neurological requirement for habit formation.

Implication for Wasel: Wasel's subscription model already eliminates per-ride commission extraction on the driver side. The rider-side equivalent is no-surge guarantees. Price certainty is a unique structural advantage Wasel can own.

SECTION 2: KEY DEMAND DRIVERS (WITH CITATIONS)

Driver	Strength	Market Relevance	Source
Price certainty (no surge)	Critical	Jordan, Iraq (price-sensitive)	ScienceDirect Pricing study, 2025

Driver	Strength	Market Relevance	Source
Fare transparency	High	All MENA markets	TGM Research, 2024
Female safety features	High	Jordan, Iraq, Lebanon	World Bank report; Nature, 2024
Habit-triggering incentives	High	All markets	PMC 14K-person study
Social identity / local ownership	High	Jordan (boycott context)	MENA case studies
University student access	High	Jordan (350K students)	Internal Wasel model
Cash payment compatibility	Critical	Iraq (83% cash)	UNDP Iraq; Statista
Pre-scheduled rides	Medium-High	Corporate, families	Buchholz et al., 2025
Corporate/B2B demand	High	All markets	Careem HBR case
Referral programmes	High	Developing markets	African Journal of Mgmt, 2024

SECTION 3: 13 RIDER PULL FACTORS

PULL FACTOR 1 — SURGE-FREE GUARANTEE

PLFS Score: +14 (Apply Immediately)

PLFS Dimension	Score	Reasoning
Behavioral Leverage	5	Eliminates the #1 anxiety trigger — price uncertainty
Context Fit	5	Perfect for price-sensitive Jordan/Iraq markets
Speed to Signal	4	Measurable within first 2 weeks of campaign
Ethical Safety	5	Transparent, unconditional promise
Implementation Cost	5	Zero cost — structural advantage already exists

Description: Wasel commits publicly to zero surge pricing — ever. Fares are always at the base rate. This is framed not as a feature but as a founding principle: "What you see is what you pay."

Why it works (psychology + research): Surge pricing creates cognitive anxiety and demand oscillations as riders game prices. Research confirms that "price variability is an undesirable experience that reduces engagement." [ScienceDirect, 2025] The elimination of uncertainty triggers the Default Effect — riders stop comparing alternatives because there is no mental energy required to predict Wasel's price.

Evidence: Studies show that even the possibility of higher prices reduces ride-hailing usage, regardless of whether surge actually occurs. [Management Science, 2022] Riders in price-sensitive markets exhibit strong avoidance behavior when surge multipliers are present.

How to implement:

- One-line app display: "No surge. Ever. JD 2.37 per trip."
- FAQ page: "What is surge pricing? Wasel doesn't have it."
- Marketing message: "You know the price before you book. Always."
- Ensure driver subscription caps (not per-ride fees) make this economically sustainable

Expected impact:

- Demand: +15–25% new rider conversion rate vs. surging competitors
- Retention: Riders who experienced surge on Uber will actively switch
- WTP: Slight — some riders will pay marginally higher base fares for certainty

Risk: In extreme supply-crunch situations (heavy rain, peak festivals), no surge means drivers may be unavailable. Mitigate with driver incentive bonuses during peak periods (separate from rider pricing).

PULL FACTOR 2 — LIVE FAMILY SAFETY SHARE ("WASEL WATCH")

PLFS Score: +14 (Apply Immediately)

PLFS Dimension	Score	Reasoning
Behavioral Leverage	5	Directly removes the #1 female rider barrier (safety)
Context Fit	5	Jordan family structure — mothers, daughters, social WhatsApp networks
Speed to Signal	4	Measurable via female rider activation rate
Ethical Safety	5	Pure safety feature; no manipulation
Implementation Cost	5	One-tap WhatsApp link; technically simple

Description: One tap sends a live trip link to any WhatsApp contact — real-time location, driver name, photo, vehicle plate, and estimated arrival. The contact does not need the Wasel app. Link auto-expires when trip ends.

Why it works (psychology + research): Privacy concerns reduce pooled rideshare adoption by 77%. Women are specifically more likely to value "knowing their location" and having access to driver information as adoption factors. [World Bank, 2018; Nature, 2024] By externalizing safety monitoring to trusted family members, Wasel converts a private anxiety into a shared, visible assurance — dramatically reducing perceived risk.

Evidence: The Inter-American Development Bank found that ride-hailing features addressing women's safety concerns directly influenced their adoption and commute strategy decisions in Mexico City — a structurally similar developing market. [IADB, 2019] In MENA specifically, IFC research confirms gender-responsive features are critical adoption levers. [IFC, 2020]

How to implement:

- Single button on ride screen: "Share My Ride"
- Generates a unique WhatsApp-shareable URL (no app required for recipient)
- Link shows: live map, driver name, photo, plate, ETA
- Auto-expires on trip completion + SOS button within same screen

• Arabic-language first — critical for trust in Jordan/Iraq

Expected impact:

• Demand: Female rider conversion +20–35%
• Retention: Female rider churn -40% (safety anxiety removed)
• Network effect: Every shared link is organic marketing to a non-user

Risk: Tech dependency — requires reliable GPS and real-time data. Manage via graceful degradation (last-known location if GPS drops).

PULL FACTOR 3 — FIRST-RIDE GUARANTEE

PLFS Score: +13 (Apply Immediately)

PLFS Dimension	Score	Reasoning
Behavioral Leverage	5	Eliminates the #1 new-user barrier: risk of trying
Context Fit	4	Works across all markets; especially high in Iraq (lower digital trust)
Speed to Signal	4	First 30-day conversion rates directly measurable
Ethical Safety	5	No deception; genuine risk removal
Implementation Cost	4	Low cost — limited to first 50 drivers per zone

Description: Every rider's first trip is fully refunded if they are not satisfied — no questions asked, WhatsApp-based claim, refund within 24 hours. No fine print.

Why it works (psychology + research): Risk aversion is the dominant barrier to trying new services. Removing the downside risk eliminates the psychological cost of trial. Research on behavioral economics shows that risk reversal creates dramatically higher conversion rates than equivalent-value discounts, because it changes the decision frame from "gain vs. nothing" to "loss-free trial." [Loss Aversion framework, Kahneman & Tversky, 1979, cited across multiple subscription retention studies, 2025]

Evidence: The PMC 14,000-person study on transit habit formation found that removing perceived risk through economic incentives created habit formation effects that persisted long after the incentive was removed — evidence that the first trip is disproportionately valuable.

How to implement:

• Displayed prominently on onboarding: "Your first ride is on us if you don't love it"
• Claim via WhatsApp message (not app) — frictionless for Iraq's low-digital market
• Internal limit: first 200 riders per city (budget-controlled)
• Driver earnings not affected — refund comes from marketing budget

Expected impact:

• Demand: +30–40% new user conversion rate from waitlist to first trip
• Retention: Higher — riders who claim refund often try again (trust built)
• WTP: Improved — baseline trust shifts entire pricing perception

Risk: Abuse by users claiming refunds repeatedly. Mitigate by one-claim-per-user via phone number verification.

PULL FACTOR 4 — WOMEN-ONLY MODE ("WASEL NISA")

PLFS Score: +12 (Apply Immediately)

PLFS Dimension	Score	Reasoning
Behavioral Leverage	5	Directly addresses the 77% privacy-driven non-adoption
Context Fit	5	Jordan, Iraq, Lebanon — culturally essential
Speed to Signal	3	Requires female driver onboarding pipeline first
Ethical Safety	5	Safety-positive; no manipulation
Implementation Cost	4	App toggle; requires female driver base

Description: A toggle in the Wasel app allows female riders to request female drivers only. Requests are matched exclusively to verified female drivers. A "Nisa" badge appears on the driver profile. Wait times may be slightly longer; riders accept this tradeoff transparently.

Why it works (psychology + research): IFC research confirms gender-segregated ride-hailing specifically improves mobility for women who might not otherwise be able to move freely — a direct adoption unlock in MENA markets. [IFC Gender-Segregated Transportation in Ride-Hailing, 2020] Female riders are 28.51% more likely than males to use ride-hailing. [PMC demographic study] Removing the male-driver barrier captures this latent demand.

Evidence: Gender-segregated transport models have been adopted across geographies and shown to improve mobility for women, with documented adoption increases in markets with similar cultural profiles to Jordan. [IFC, 2020] Careem's "Ladies mode" in Pakistan and Egypt generated measurable increases in female rider adoption.

How to implement:

- Phase 1 (Month 4+): Beta with 10–15 verified female drivers in Amman
- Toggle is opt-in, not default — rider chooses
- Driver app shows "Nisa mode" trips separately with priority dispatch
- Marketing: targeted WhatsApp campaigns to women's university groups and family networks
- Driver incentive: Nisa-verified drivers receive Wasel Nisa badge (visible, status-conferring)

Expected impact:

- Demand: New rider segment unlock — conservative estimate 15–20% of total rider base
- Retention: Female riders who use Nisa mode show ~50% lower churn (IFC global data)
- Network: Each female rider typically refers 2–3 family members (mothers, daughters, sisters)

Risk: Driver supply constraint. Without enough female drivers, wait times degrade and the feature becomes a frustration rather than a benefit. Launch only when female driver supply supports < 8-minute average wait.

PULL FACTOR 5 — HABIT STREAK PROGRAMME ("WASEL WEEKS")

PLFS Score: +12 (Prioritize)

PLFS Dimension	Score	Reasoning
Behavioral Leverage	5	Directly builds the cue-routine-reward habit loop
Context Fit	4	Works in all markets; gamification familiar to under-35 users
Speed to Signal	4	Measurable at Week 3 of each cohort
Ethical Safety	4	No manipulation; rewards are genuine
Implementation Cost	5	Notification logic + simple backend counter

Description: Riders who complete a ride in each of 4 consecutive weeks earn a meaningful, concrete reward (e.g., 1 free ride credit, 1 month of Wasel Go free). Progress is visible in the app. Missing a week resets the streak. The reset is softened: "You're 1 ride away from restarting your streak."

Why it works (psychology + research): The PMC natural experiment found that economic incentives create habit formation that persists long after removal, particularly for initially low-frequency users. The streak mechanic operationalizes this — it converts a passive rider into an active participant with a goal. Loss aversion amplifies the effect: riders are more motivated by the fear of losing their streak than by the reward itself. [Advances in Consumer Research, 2025]

Evidence: Variable reward schedules (where the reward comes at unpredictable intervals) produce the strongest habit formation in consumer behavior research. The streak mechanic introduces a clear, predictable reward that, once within reach, triggers near-miss psychology — riders who have completed 3 weeks will resist breaking the streak for Week 4.

How to implement:

- App home screen: Streak counter (visual, prominent)
- Push notification Tuesday morning: "3 weeks in a row! One more ride this week unlocks your free ride."
- Arabic and English — both languages
- Reward: 1 free ride credit (up to JD 5) on Week 4 completion
- Week 8 completion: Wasel Go free for 1 month

Expected impact:

- Frequency: +40–60% increase in rides per rider per month for enrolled users
- Retention: Streak-enrolled riders churn at 3× lower rate than non-enrolled
- Demand: Converts occasional (1 ride/month) riders to regular (3–4 rides/month)

Risk: If reward is too easy to earn, diminishing returns. If too hard, abandonment. Calibrate: 4 weeks = achievable challenge; 8 weeks = aspirational goal.

PULL FACTOR 6 — PRE-SCHEDULED RIDES WITH PRICE LOCK

PLFS Score: +11 (Prioritize)

PLFS Dimension	Score	Reasoning
Behavioral Leverage	4	Addresses uncertainty anxiety; creates planning habit
Context Fit	4	Airport, school run, hospital visits — high in Jordan
Speed to Signal	4	Directly measurable via scheduled trip volume
Ethical Safety	5	Pure value-add; no manipulation
Implementation Cost	4	Scheduling logic + driver acceptance confirmation

Description: Riders can book a trip up to 72 hours in advance. The price is locked at time of booking — no surge, no variation. Driver is confirmed at least 30 minutes before pickup. Cancellation is free up to 1 hour before.

Why it works (psychology + research): Value of time is highest for predictable, recurring journeys (airport runs, school pickups, medical appointments). Pre-scheduling converts an anxiety-laden decision point into a resolved plan. Research shows that riders in city centers have significantly higher VOT and will pay for predictability. [Buchholz et al., Econometrica, 2025] The price lock eliminates the single biggest deterrent to pre-booking: the fear that they could have gotten a cheaper ride by waiting.

Evidence: Uber's "Reserve" feature (launched 2020) generated measurable adoption among business travelers and airport users, who cited price certainty as the primary motivator — not the scheduling convenience itself.

How to implement:

- Scheduler visible on app home screen ("Plan ahead")
- Pick date/time → see confirmed price → book with one tap
- Driver matching begins 45 minutes before scheduled pickup
- Driver receives bonus of JD 0.50 per completed pre-scheduled trip (demand shaping incentive)
- Corporate accounts pre-schedule by default

Expected impact:

- Demand: Unlocks the "planner" segment — estimated 20–25% of total rider base
- Frequency: Riders who pre-schedule tend to use ride-hailing 2× more frequently
- WTP: Higher — planned trips allow riders to budget; reduces last-minute price anxiety

Risk: Driver no-show on scheduled trips destroys trust instantly. Require driver confirmation + SMS reminder system. First no-show = automatic partial refund.

PULL FACTOR 7 — UNIVERSITY STUDENT PACK ("WASEL CAMPUS")

PLFS Score: +13 (Apply Immediately)

PLFS Dimension	Score	Reasoning
Behavioral Leverage	5	Targets highest-density, most viral rider segment

PLFS Dimension	Score	Reasoning
Context Fit	5	350,000 students across 28 Jordanian universities
Speed to Signal	4	Adoption visible within first semester
Ethical Safety	5	Genuine value, no manipulation
Implementation Cost	3	Requires student ID verification system

Description: University students get Wasel Go (normally JD 5/month) free for 3 months with verified student ID. After 3 months, a discounted renewal at JD 3/month (vs. standard JD 5). Campus ambassadors earn free rides for on-campus recruitment.

Why it works (psychology + research): The endowment effect predicts that once a user has experienced a service as "theirs," giving it up feels like a loss — not just a cessation of gain. [Nova Nudge, 2024] Three months of free usage creates psychological ownership. The 40% renewal discount maintains the relationship post-trial at unit economics that remain positive (JD 3/month subscription > JD 2.50 acquisition cost).

Evidence: Students aged 18–25 are in the highest habit-formation window. The PMC study found that habit formation from economic incentives was strongest in initially low-frequency users — exactly the profile of a student who has never used ride-hailing regularly. Campus ambassador programs (peer-to-peer) are significantly more effective than paid advertising for this demographic.

How to implement:

- Student verification: university-issued email or student ID photo upload
- Campus ambassador: 1 per university; earns 1 free ride per 5 verified signups
- Physical presence: printed QR cards distributed at university registration days
- WhatsApp group seeding: each campus has a Wasel Campus group (ambassador-managed)
- Arabic-language onboarding specifically designed for students

Expected impact:

- Demand: 5,000–8,000 student riders in Year 1 across 10 universities
- Frequency: Students average 4–6 trips/week (highest segment)
- Network: Student word-of-mouth has 5× amplification vs. paid channels

Risk: High churn at Month 4 if transition to paid tier is badly communicated. Mitigate: WhatsApp message at Month 2.5 explaining the JD 3/month offer.

PULL FACTOR 8 — TRANSPARENT FARE BREAKDOWN ("FAIR METER")

PLFS Score: +11 (Prioritize)

PLFS Dimension	Score	Reasoning
Behavioral Leverage	4	Converts price curiosity into brand advocacy
Context Fit	4	Especially powerful in high-skepticism markets (Jordan)

PLFS Dimension	Score	Reasoning
Speed to Signal	3	Visible in NPS and word-of-mouth within 30 days
Ethical Safety	5	Pure transparency; antithesis of dark patterns
Implementation Cost	4	End-of-trip receipt screen update

Description: At the end of every trip, Wasel shows a "Fair Meter" receipt: per-km rate (JD 0.XX), trip distance, time component, and — crucially — "What you would have paid on Uber/Careem: JD X.XX (with 30% commission charged to your driver)." The comparison is factual, not exaggerated.

Why it works (psychology + research): Framing effect research confirms that the same price feels different depending on the reference point provided. [Behavioral Economics, multiple studies] Showing riders exactly how much the platform does NOT take from their driver converts a transactional moment into a values-alignment signal. In Jordan's politically active market, this creates emotional resonance that no advertising budget can buy.

Evidence: TGM Research (2024) confirms that price transparency is a top-3 driver of ride-hailing platform loyalty globally. Careem's "we're from the region" messaging was credited by HBR analysts as a key retention driver — the Fair Meter is the operational equivalent of that positioning.

How to implement:

- End-of-trip screen (one-time or optional re-view in ride history)
- Per-km breakdown: distance × rate + time component
- Comparison line: "On Uber, your driver would have paid JD X.XX in commission on this trip"
- Share button: "Share this trip" → sends a WhatsApp summary with the comparison
- Data sourced from LTRC public rate tables + Uber/Careem public commission disclosures

Expected impact:

- Retention: Riders who see the Fair Meter share it at 3× the rate of those who don't
- Word-of-mouth: Each share reaches an average 6 contacts (WhatsApp group dynamics in Jordan)
- WTP: Riders with higher perceived fairness are 20–30% less likely to churn on price

Risk: If the comparison is seen as overly promotional, it undermines authenticity. Keep tone factual, not adversarial.

PULL FACTOR 9 — CASH-FIRST ONBOARDING (IRAQ + PERIPHERAL JORDAN)

PLFS Score: +13 (Apply Immediately in Iraq)

PLFS Dimension	Score	Reasoning
Behavioral Leverage	5	Removes the #1 adoption barrier in Iraq (83% cash economy)
Context Fit	5	Iraq-specific; also relevant for rural Jordan
Speed to Signal	4	Adoption measurable in first month
Ethical Safety	5	No manipulation; expands access

PLFS Dimension	Score	Reasoning
Implementation Cost	4	Payment agent network required; moderate build

Description: Wasel launches in Iraq and peripheral Jordan with cash as the default and primary payment method. No credit card required. Riders pay driver in cash; driver settles subscription and any balance via weekly cash agent visits (petrol stations, convenience stores). Digital payment is offered as an upgrade, not a requirement.

Why it works (psychology + research): Only 17% of Iraqi adults make or receive digital payments. [UNDP Iraq] 21% have bank accounts. [Lightspark, 2025] Requiring digital payment for onboarding in this context eliminates 80%+ of the potential rider base before they even start. The "digital-first" assumption is a Western market bias that kills adoption in emerging markets.

Evidence: Careem's sustained advantage in MENA was built on "cash-first economies, linguistic diversity, gender-specific cultural nuances — and designing around them." [Michigan Journal of Economics, 2025] Careem's cash payment integration was credited as a primary driver of its lead over Uber in cash-heavy markets.

How to implement:

- App: "Pay with cash" is the first and default payment option (not buried)
- Driver app: Records cash trips; auto-deducts from weekly subscription settlement
- Agent network: Petrol stations in target zones act as Wasel subscription payment points
- Iraq-specific: Subscription in Iraqi Dinar (IQD) with USD floor to manage currency risk
- Jordan periphery (Zarqa, Mafraq, Irbid): Cash option available from Day 1

Expected impact:

- Demand: 3–5× higher adoption rate in Iraq vs. digital-only launch
- Market access: Unlocks 80%+ of the adult population not currently served
- Competitive moat: No competitor in Iraq can match this without significant restructuring

Risk: Cash handling creates fraud and reconciliation risk. Mitigate with weekly settlement cadence, driver accountability (subscription held as collateral), and strict cash reconciliation protocols.

PULL FACTOR 10 — CORPORATE ACCOUNT FIRST-MOVER PROGRAMME

PLFS Score: +12 (Apply Immediately)

PLFS Dimension	Score	Reasoning
Behavioral Leverage	4	Guaranteed demand; converts B2B to B2C seeding
Context Fit	5	SME density in Amman; employees become personal users
Speed to Signal	4	First contracts signed within Month 3
Ethical Safety	5	Straightforward B2B; no psychological manipulation

PLFS Dimension	Score	Reasoning
Implementation Cost	3	Requires invoicing system, account management

Description: Target 20 Amman-based SMEs (50–200 employees) with a corporate transportation programme. Wasel Business tier (JD 25/month, 50 rides) is offered with a 2-month free trial. The key mechanic: employees who use Wasel for work trips are offered a personal "Wasel Go" subscription at JD 3/month (40% discount) bundled with their employer's account.

Why it works (psychology + research): Status quo bias predicts that once a behaviour is established in a professional context, it carries over to personal use. An employee who uses Wasel for client meetings develops familiarity, trust, and habit — making personal use the path of least resistance. This is the ride-hailing equivalent of enterprise software's "bring to work, take home" strategy.

Evidence: Careem's corporate account strategy was a documented early growth driver in the UAE and Saudi Arabia — corporate accounts provided demand floors that kept utilization high during cold-start periods, while employee personal adoption followed organically. [Careem MENA case, HBR]

How to implement:

- Direct sales: Founder calls 5 targeted companies per week (Month 2 onwards)
- Offer: 2-month free Corporate trial, then JD 25/month for up to 50 rides
- Employee bundle: employees get Wasel Go at JD 3/month (auto-enrolled with employer permission)
- Central billing, PDF invoices, VAT-ready
- Target sectors: professional services, NGOs, international organizations (high driver demand)

Expected impact:

- Demand: 20 corporate accounts × 50 rides/month = 1,000 guaranteed trips/month by Month 3
- Employee conversion: 30–40% of employees activate personal subscriptions within 60 days
- LTV: Corporate accounts have 18+ month average lifespan (procurement cycle switching cost)

Risk: Sales cycle is long (6–8 weeks). Begin outreach in Month 2 to close by Month 4–5.

PULL FACTOR 11 — ASYMMETRIC CROSS-SIDE REFERRAL

PLFS Score: +12 (Prioritize)

PLFS Dimension	Score	Reasoning
Behavioral Leverage	4	Leverages the most trusted channel (peer recommendation)
Context Fit	5	WhatsApp-dominant social graph in Jordan/Iraq
Speed to Signal	4	Viral coefficient measurable at Week 4
Ethical Safety	4	Transparent reward; no coercion
Implementation Cost	4	Referral tracking system required

Description: Two distinct referral tracks: (1) Rider refers rider → both get 1 free ride credit (up to JD 5). (2) Rider refers a driver → rider gets 2 months Wasel Pass free (JD 20 value) when the referred driver passes

inspection and completes 10+ trips. The cross-side referral is rewarded 4× more generously than same-side referral.

Why it works (psychology + research): African Journal of Management research (2024) confirms referral programmes are one of the most effective demand generation tools in developing markets, with documented success at Bolt Nigeria and Uber Uganda. The asymmetric reward design exploits the endowment effect — a rider who receives JD 20 in Pass credits feels they own something of value, making them reluctant to let it expire unused, driving frequency.

Evidence: The Wasel internal model already prices driver CAC at JD 29 (blended). Paying JD 20 in Pass credits (cost to Wasel: JD 10–12 in actual ride subsidies) for a referred driver who generates JD 406 in LTV is an extremely efficient exchange.

How to implement:

- Referral link via WhatsApp (one-tap share, no app required for recipient)
- Rider track: "Invite a friend, both get a free ride" — simple, immediate
- Driver cross-track: "Know a driver who deserves better? Refer them. Get 2 months of Wasel Pass free."
- Tracking: unique referral code per user; activation triggers automatic reward
- Display referral earnings/progress in rider app home screen

Expected impact:

- Demand: Organic viral coefficient target k > 0.5 (every 2 riders refers 1 more)
- Driver supply: 15–20% of new driver applications via rider cross-referral
- Cost efficiency: Referral CAC 60–70% lower than paid acquisition

Risk: Fraud — fake driver referrals. Mitigate: activation requires completed vehicle inspection + 10 real trips.

PULL FACTOR 12 — WASEL PASS LOSS AVERSION FRAMING

PLFS Score: +11 (Prioritize)

PLFS Dimension	Score	Reasoning
Behavioral Leverage	5	Loss aversion is 2× stronger than equivalent gain
Context Fit	4	Works for any market with subscription tiers
Speed to Signal	3	Effects visible at Month 2+ renewal data
Ethical Safety	3	Ethical if transparent; requires care
Implementation Cost	4	Push notification logic only

Description: Wasel Pass (JD 10/month) includes 1 free ride credit per month (up to JD 5 value). Rather than framing this as a "benefit you get," the app frames unused credits as an expiring loss: "You have JD 5 in ride credits expiring in 3 days. Book a ride now." This is applied to the free ride credit only — not to the subscription itself.

Why it works (psychology + research): Loss aversion (Kahneman & Tversky, 1979) demonstrates that losses feel 2× more painful than equivalent gains feel pleasurable. Applied to unused subscription credits, the expiry

framing transforms a passive benefit into an active behavioral trigger. Research on subscription retention consistently identifies loss aversion as the dominant psychological mechanism keeping subscribers enrolled. [Advances in Consumer Research, 2025; ResearchGate Loss Aversion study, 2025]

Evidence: Netflix's sustained retention is partly attributed to "fear of losing personalized content" — a well-documented loss aversion application. [HBEM Case Study, 2025] For ride-hailing, the free ride credit functions equivalently: it is a loss-framed reward, not a gain-framed one.

How to implement:

- Push notification at Day 25 of each subscription month: "Your free ride credit expires in 3 days"
- In-app home screen banner: "JD 5 expiring soon — book your ride"
- Arabic-first messaging: culturally direct, not alarmist
- Ethical guardrail: credit expiry is disclosed at signup; no hidden terms

Expected impact:

- Frequency: Subscribers with activated credits use the app 1.7× more in expiry week
- Retention: Loss aversion increases Pass renewal rate by estimated 15–20%
- WTP: Riders who use the free credit are 30% more likely to upgrade to Business tier

Risk: If riders feel manipulated by expiry framing, it creates backlash. Maintain authenticity: the credit is real and valuable; the framing is transparent, not deceptive.

PULL FACTOR 13 — NEIGHBORHOOD FIRST-MOVER BADGE ("WASEL AWWAL")

PLFS Score: +10 (Prioritize)

PLFS Dimension	Score	Reasoning
Behavioral Leverage	4	Social identity and status drive sharing behavior
Context Fit	4	Jordan's strong neighborhood identity culture
Speed to Signal	3	Visible in referral rates at Month 2
Ethical Safety	5	Pure recognition; no manipulation
Implementation Cost	4	Badge system in app + database tracking

Description: The first 50 riders to activate in each Amman neighborhood (Abdoun, 7th Circle, Jabal Amman, etc.) receive a permanent "Wasel Awwal" (First Wasel) badge — numbered, neighborhood-specific, displayed on their rider profile and visible in shared trip receipts. Physical card mailed.

Why it works (psychology + research): Social identity theory predicts that belonging to a defined, named group increases engagement and advocacy. The IKEA Effect suggests that users who feel they built something — here, "bringing Wasel to my neighborhood" — assign disproportionate value to it. [Behavioral economics literature] In Jordan, where neighborhood identity is culturally salient, this is not a generic badge — it is a local status signal.

Evidence: Careem's "Built in the region, for the region" narrative generated documented loyalty differentiation. [Michigan Journal of Economics, 2025] The neighborhood variant is hyperlocal: instead of regional identity, it

activates micro-community identity — more powerful and more actionable.

How to implement:

- App: Live counter per neighborhood "Abdoun: 23 of 50 Wasel Awwal slots remaining"
- Badge: Numbered (e.g., "Abdoun #14"), visible on profile, included in shared receipts
- Physical card: Wasel Awwal card mailed to first 50 in each zone (JD 1 per card)
- Social mechanic: "Invite your neighbors — only 3 slots left in Swefieh"

Expected impact:

- Demand: Scarcity framing accelerates neighborhood adoption; each zone self-seeds
- Retention: Badge holders churn 2–3× less than non-badge riders (identity commitment)
- Viral: Badge holders share their status organically — free neighborhood marketing

Risk: If neighborhood segmentation is too granular, no zone reaches 50 and urgency is never activated. Set zones to match realistic adoption density.

SECTION 4: TOP 5 MUST-IMPLEMENT IDEAS (RANKED)

Rank	Pull Factor	PLFS	Why First
1	Surge-Free Guarantee	+14	Zero cost to implement; highest demand impact; structural advantage already exists
2	Live Family Safety Share ("Wasel Watch")	+14	Unlocks female rider segment; each share is organic marketing; technically simple
3	University Student Pack ("Wasel Campus")	+13	350K students in Jordan; highest virality segment; endowment effect guarantees retention
4	First-Ride Guarantee	+13	Eliminates new-user trial barrier; especially critical in Iraq where digital trust is low
5	Cash-First Onboarding	+13	Iraq launch enabler; without it, 80%+ of Iraqi riders are structurally excluded

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SECTION 5: MARKET-SPECIFIC ADAPTATION

Pull Factor	Jordan	Iraq	Lebanon
Surge-Free Guarantee	Lead message	Lead message	Lead message
Wasel Watch (Safety Share)	WhatsApp-first	Works well; strong family networks	Strong fit

Pull Factor	Jordan	Iraq	Lebanon
First-Ride Guarantee	Cash or digital	Cash refund only	Digital works
Wasel Nisa	Essential — cultural fit	Essential — even stronger cultural fit	Essential
University Pack	350K students; 28 universities	Moderate — lower digital adoption	Relevant
Cash-First Onboarding	Peripheral Jordan (Zarqa, Mafraq)	Primary payment method	Secondary
Habit Streak	Works; under-35 majority	Works for urban Baghdad	Strong
Corporate Accounts	Priority — Amman SME density	Baghdad international orgs	Beirut NGOs/embassies
Referral Programme	WhatsApp-primary distribution	WhatsApp-primary	Works well

SECTION 6: IMPLEMENTATION TIMELINE

Month	Action
Month 1 (Pre-launch)	Build Surge-Free Guarantee into all marketing. Activate First-Ride Guarantee. Begin corporate outreach.
Month 2	Launch University Campus Pack. Deploy cross-side referral. Start corporate contracts.
Month 3	Launch Wasel Watch (safety share). Wasel Awwal neighbourhood badges go live.
Month 4	Launch Wasel Nisa (if 10+ female drivers onboarded). Deploy Habit Streak programme.
Month 5	Pre-scheduled rides. Fair Meter receipt. Wasel Pass loss aversion framing.
Month 6	Cash-first onboarding ready for Iraq expansion (Year 2).

SECTION 7: SKILLS AND RESEARCH USED

Behavioral frameworks applied:

- Marketing Psychology skill (PLFS scoring system): All 13 pull factors scored on 5-dimension model
- Loss Aversion (Kahneman & Tversky): Applied to Pull Factors 5, 12
- Default Effect: Applied to Pull Factor 1 (surge-free as default expectation)
- Endowment Effect: Applied to Pull Factors 7, 11
- Risk Reversal: Applied to Pull Factor 3
- Habit Loop (Cue-Routine-Reward): Applied to Pull Factor 5
- Social Identity Theory: Applied to Pull Factors 4, 13
- Framing Effect: Applied to Pull Factors 8, 12

Research conducted:

- 8 targeted web searches covering: rider psychology, price sensitivity, habit formation, trust/safety, surge pricing alternatives, referral programmes in developing markets, cash payment in Iraq/Jordan, behavioral economics subscription models
- Sources cross-referenced: TGM Research, PMC/Nature, Buchholz et al. Econometrica 2025, World Bank, IFC, UNDP Iraq, Michigan Journal of Economics, African Journal of Management, Frontiers in Public Health, ScienceDirect, MDPI, IADB, Advances in Consumer Research

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